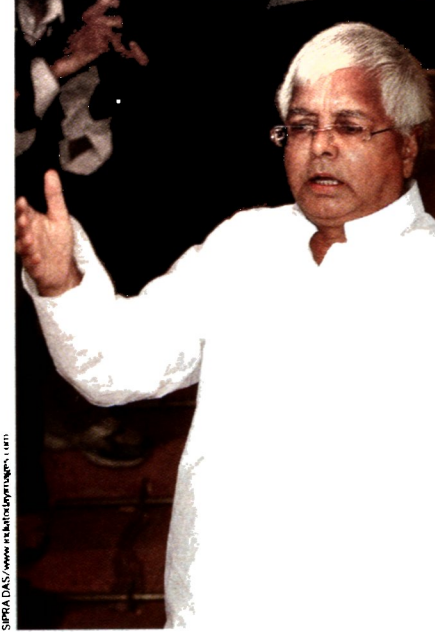
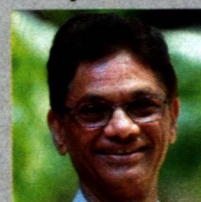




MULAYAM, SHARAD AND LALU YADAV, THE UPA'S PART-TIME FRIENDS AND PART-TIME FOES, HAVE NOW TURNED STRATEGIC ALLIES

The census may well give us a new social map of India. Reservations are based on caste, but then castes are loosely, administratively defined. Why is a caste sc in one part of the country and an OBC in other parts? "Dhobis" are scs in West Bengal, Uttar Pradesh, Bihar and Rajasthan but are considered oBCs in Maharashtra. No caste is a monolith and hence cannot be put in a single basket.

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opposed this. Privately, some politicians admit that once the new figures are out, chaos will follow. Apart from which is the problem of logistics. Some communities like the Meenas are considered tribals in Rajasthan and OBCs in Madhya Pradesh. This is what Chidambaram was worried about when he told Parliament that unlike the SCs/STs, the OBCs have a separate state and Central list.

Moreover, the last election has shown that caste-based politics is on the decline, particularly in Uttar Pradesh. Rahul Gandhi cited the Congress win of 21 seats in E-2009 as "a vote for politics of development over caste". While Lalu was wiped out, Nitish Kumar has an alliance with the upper caste-dominated BJP, and even Mayawati went for a social remix by reaching out to Brahmins in 2007 and discarding her anti-Manuwadi politics. The party gladly accepted the slogan of Satish Mishra, the BSP's first Brahmin national general secretary, that the elephant symbol was in fact Lord Ganesha. This social arithmetic is in for another churning, once the census comes out with its findings of new pressure groups.

There is a class system—or a caste system—in the government too. The so-called social justice votaries are everybody's favourite stereotypes in the politics of divide and rule. They feel there is a kind of Brahminical hierarchy in the power pyramid and they are outsiders in

the Delhi durbar, grudgingly tolerated for their utility. In the bureaucracy too, the numbers tell the story of disparity. The minority of the lesser castes in services only emphasises the fact that bad social development models intensify the sense of marginalisation.

Quotas are bad, and this should not distract us from the reality of unequal opportunities and injustice prevalent not only at the social level but in the bureaucracy and political structure as well. The entire blame can't be put on history or tradition. It is a huge failure of the state in ensuring opportunities for the socially as well as the economically backward. There are ways other than caste-based reservation to make India a country of equal opportunities. Economic status should be the only criterion for the Government in identifying those who need the helping hand of the state. There is also something fundamentally wrong with our development model. Why is it that, even more than six decades after Independence and despite all the socialist rhetoric by successive governments, India is an unequal country where millions are resigned to the fate of acute dispossession? We can't eradicate caste. We can do a lot more against casteism and the kind of social engineering that makes 21st century India an OBC—an Ominously Backward Country.

with Farzand Ahmed, Amitabh Srivastava, Ambresh Mishra and Lakshmi Subramanian

1,963

is the number of castes in the Central list of OBCs, which includes 4,000 sub-castes. Each state has its own list of OBCs.